

CIRCLE OF YOUNG HUMANITARIANS THEORY OF CHANGE

While we often speak of the humanitarian world as if it exists somewhere out there, the CYH's Theory of Change understands that it is right here—within you, me, and us. It is defined by our ability to foster self-agency and relate to one another in a dignified and respectful manner. We believe that change arises from humanitarian habits that sustain purposeful practices, reform structures, and promote better cultures.

The Theory of Change (ToC) of the Circle of Young Humanitarians (CYH) outlines a comprehensive pathway designed to empower young people to become engaged and informed participants in the world. The ToC is structured around a progression of stages that guide young individuals from feelings of helplessness and disengagement to becoming empowered change-makers who drive positive transformation within their communities and beyond.

The ToC recognizes that both individual and collective efforts are required to tackle systemic issues at their core. On an individual level, we work to transform feelings of disempowerment into action. On a collective level, we create opportunities for education, exchange, and engagement.

While the ToC acknowledges that it will take time to see the rewards of this type of humanitarian work, we are already beginning to witness what we call the Humanitarian Spillover Effect (HSE), when acts of humanity inspire more acts of humanity and change how we relate to each other.

BECOMING A HUMANITARIAN ISN'T ABOUT HAVING ALL THE ANSWERS—IT'S ABOUT BEING WILLING TO ENGAGE, TO LEARN, AND TO ACT WITH MORE INTENTION.

THE KEY HAS ALWAYS BEEN IN YOUR HANDS. THE CHOICE TO USE IT IS YOURS.

- 1 HELPLESSNESS TO AWARENESS**
What do you do when you feel disempowered by the magnitude of global challenges?
- 2 AWARENESS TO UNDERSTANDING**
Awareness of humanitarian issues is not enough to drive meaningful action. Young people need a deeper understanding of the complexities of global challenges.
- 3 UNDERSTANDING TO INTERNALIZATION**
Gaining a deeper understanding of humanitarian issues is an important step, but true transformation occurs when learning is internalized. This stage requires introspection, an internal process that bridges intellectual understanding with personal conviction.
- 4 INTERNALIZATION TO TRUST**
Even after having internalized learning, young people often lack the trust needed to engage in humanitarian action. Without confidence in their abilities and the support of a larger community, we risk remaining passive observers.
- 5 TRUST TO SELF-AGENCY**
While trust is essential, it must be accompanied by practical tools and opportunities for young people to take action. Moving from understanding to action requires an enabling environment.
- 6 SELF-AGENCY TO CULTURAL CHANGE**
Individual actions, while important, need to create broader societal shifts to have a lasting impact.
- 7 CULTURAL CHANGE TO SYSTEMIC CHANGE**
For cultural change to translate into systemic change, it must influence institutions, policies, and societal structures.

HUMANITARIAN HABITS

Humanitarian values exist within all of us, waiting to be unlocked. Our responses to the world are shaped by repetition and familiarity, forming habits that can either deepen our compassion or desensitize us. With the constant flood of global events, it takes extra effort to stay open, engaged, and empathetic rather than

feeling overwhelmed or numb. Unlocking your inner humanitarian requires awareness, intentional effort, and the commitment to building new habits.

We've broken this process down into **four key steps**—each designed to help you tap into what's already within you.

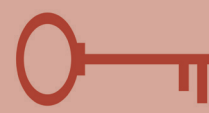


AWARENESS: NOTICING THE KEYHOLE

Developing awareness is the first step. It's like pressing pause on autopilot, noticing patterns in your thoughts and reactions. Before you can unlock a door, you have to see the keyhole. It's easy to overlook, but paying attention allows you to stay curious about what lies beyond.

Example: Become aware of how world news affects you. Acknowledge its existence and the impact it has.

WHEN?
Whenever you notice a strong reaction, pause! Are you outraged? Disappointed?

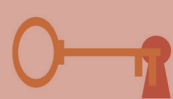


UNDERSTANDING: FINDING THE KEY

Once you've noticed the keyhole, the next step is to seek knowledge—to find the key. Understanding requires moving beyond surface-level information and engaging with complexity in a way that is thoughtful, critical, and compassionate.

Example: Learn about the historical, social, and political layers of the war in Gaza, ensuring your perspective remains informed and balanced.

WHAT?
Empower your feeling with information, define it! Keep asking questions.



INTERNALIZATION: TURNING THE KEY

Understanding alone isn't enough—it has to be internalized. This step requires self-reflection, integration, and a willingness to accept difficult truths. It's about making the knowledge personal and connecting it to your own reality.

Example: Explore how the war in Gaza connects to Swiss realities. Consider its ripple effects on policy, media, public discourse, and mental health.

WHY?
Connect dots with convictions, self-reflect! There is always more to learn.



TRUST & SELF-AGENCY: WALKING THROUGH THE DOOR

Unlocking the door isn't the final step—you have to walk through it. This means applying what you've learned, standing by your values, and engaging with the world in real time.

Ex: In discussions where people take rigid sides, assert the importance of remaining impartial, fostering dialogue rather than division.

HOW?
Engage with your immediate reality, be brave! Don't be afraid to mess up, we all do.

HUMANITARIAN WAYFINDER

The CYH Humanitarian Wayfinder is a practical guide designed to help you visualize and embark on the inner humanitarian work essential for cultivating a deeper sense of self-agency.

This guide includes the CYH Theory of Change, a foundational framework that outlines how cultural transformation becomes possible. The Wayfinder is just one of many ways to put this theory into action. We break down each step into a series of habits that can be developed and strengthened over time. Additionally, we explore the different scales of inner humanitarian work and provide practical tools and skills to support your personal journey.

This guide is a living document—continuously evolving as we learn and grow. We invite you to engage with it, adapt it to your own experience, and join us in shaping a more just, beautiful, brave, and empowered world.



CYH Wayfinder 1.0 - 2025
Circle of Young Humanitarians
circleofyounghumanitarians.ch

CYH Wayfinder 1.0 - 2025

UNLOCK YOUR INNER HUMANITARIAN!

HUMANITARIAN WAYFINDER



UNLOCKING YOUR INNER HUMANITARIAN JOURNEY

The journey of unlocking your inner humanitarian and stepping into a more expansive consciousness is always within reach. This process is infinite in its potential—you can summon the door at any time, identify the keyhole, find and turn the key, and step into a more humanitarian world.

The Four Levels of Humanitarian Unlocking

Personal Unlocking: Turning Inward
This first step is often the most challenging step as it is solitary work that requires honest reflection, self-awareness and emotional intelligence. Practice!

Example: If you feel overwhelmed by the news, take a moment to connect with your own emotions. Recognize that your distress is a sign of deep care and compassion—an entry point to your humanitarian consciousness.

Interpersonal Unlocking: Strengthening Relationships and Communities
This step focuses on how we engage with those closest to us. Our relationships shape our immediate world, and by practicing vulnerability and compassion, we create ripple effects in our personal spheres and greater communities.

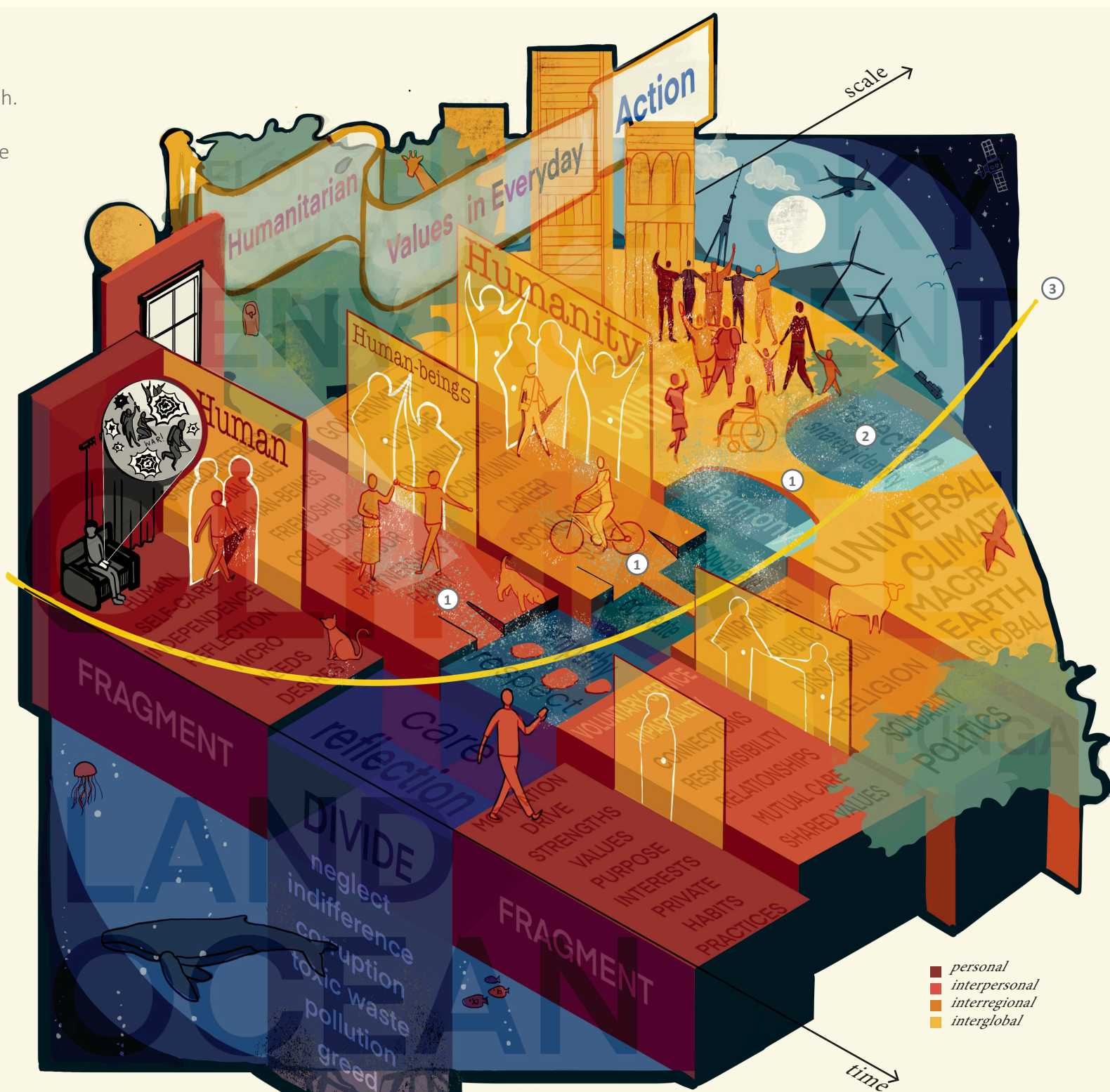
Example: Ask yourself—how can I be more open, honest, and empathetic with the people I care about most? How can I foster deeper trust and connection?

Interregional Unlocking: Awareness of Local Injustices
True humanitarianism requires us to look beyond our immediate circles and recognize injustices within our larger communities. This step demands an understanding of privilege, power dynamics, and the varied lived experiences of those around us, including our environment.

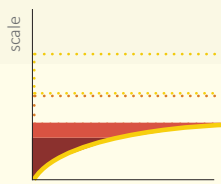
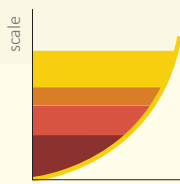
Example: Educate yourself on social inequalities in your region. Who is most affected? What barriers exist? How can you contribute to meaningful change?

Interglobal Unlocking: Understanding Systemic Histories
The final step is an even deeper dive—understanding the histories of oppression that shape our world today. True global consciousness acknowledges the lasting impact of colonialism, systemic inequities, climate change, and the structures that continue to divide us.

Example: Reflect on how global conflicts, economic disparities, and histories of oppression connect to present-day struggles. Recognize that, more than ever, we need each other to create a more just world.



The Trajectory of In/Justice:
Visualizing the Arc Across Time and Scale



Where along the arc are you? In which direction are you headed?
Towards more connection or more fragmentation?
What about our world? There's no right or wrong answer, just an honest review. The trajectory can change at any given moment.
It's up to you.

- 1 Humanitarian Spillover Effect (HSE)**
When we learn to treat each other with greater humanity, including ourselves, we automatically empower each other, there is a positive ripple effect outward. It decominates and rejuvenates our streams. HSE strengthens human bonds and fosters deeper connection, transforming not just individuals but entire communities.
- 2 Stream of Humanitarian Consciousness**
New connections and bonds are possible when bridges are built across shared truths and understanding.
- 3 Arc of Morality**
"The arc of the moral universe is long, but it bends towards justice." - Martin Luther King
It only bends toward justice because people direct it towards justice; it doesn't happen on its own.



COMPASS

Your moral compass shapes your actions, and practicing these values in real time strengthens your commitment to them. By connecting with yourself, your surroundings, and your community, you reinforce the foundation of humanitarian work. The fundamental humanitarian principles include: humanity, impartiality, neutrality, independence, universality, unity, voluntary service. Here are examples of how they can be broken down into human values. Which resonate with you most?

shared humanity, respect, compassion, integrity, solidarity, justice, empathy, human dignity, accountability, non-discrimination, sustainability,...

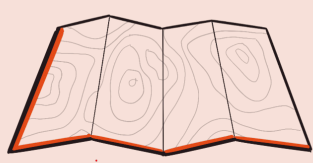
- Define your **moral compass** by reflecting on what matters to you:

- What do you care about? What frustrates you (which is another way of identifying what you care about)?
- How do they connect to humanitarian values or how can you integrate them more proactively?
- Who shares these values with you? Community strengthens moral compass!

Examples:

I care about human dignity. At work when there are discussions about trans rights, I'll practice this value by proactively addressing transphobic comments that implicitly attack the dignity of trans people.

I care about impartiality. When I find myself in a political debate, I'll restrain myself from making broadstroke generalizations. I'll remind myself that there are always learning opportunities when ideas clash.



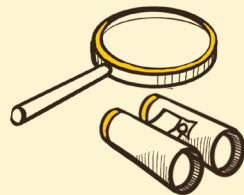
MAP

Learning to read your landscape helps you identify injustices and privileges. A layered map will require the ability to face objective facts and how they effect lived experiences. Whether it's the struggles of marginalized communities, the impact of climate change, or the hidden biases in everyday systems, expanding your "map" awareness helps you navigate complex realities and take informed action.

- Assess one aspect of your **map** by reflecting on your privilege:

- Did you ever have to worry about food or shelter growing up?
- Did you feel psychologically and/or emotionally unsafe at home?
- Have you ever faced significant barriers to accessing education or employment?
- Have you ever experienced discrimination based on your race or ethnicity?
- Have you ever felt unsafe because of your gender?
- Can you be open about your sexual orientation without fear of judgement or repercussions?
- Is your first language not the same as the national language?
- Do you have any physical/mental disabilities or struggle with mental health?
- Have you ever felt pressure to conform to norms that do not resonate with your identity?

Take the time to reflect on your answers to these "Yes" and "No" questions. If you answer "No" to most of these questions you're in a privileged position. Reflecting on privilege builds self-awareness, fosters empathy, promotes social responsibility, improves communication, and enhances problem-solving by helping you recognize systemic inequalities, understand diverse experiences, and engage more thoughtfully and equitably with others. It's not about guilt or shame, but increased understanding.



PERSPECTIVE

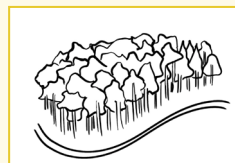
How can you zoom in/out and learn to recognize the value and limitations of your specific perspective? How to increase knowledge and understanding by welcoming different perspectives?

- Describe and reflect on each image, each a different **perspective**:

- Information Assessment:** What specific insights or knowledge does each image or perspective reveal that others might miss?
- Beyond Right and Wrong:** Is one perspective objectively more accurate than another, or do they each capture different aspects of a complex reality?
- Embracing Uncertainty:** How can we acknowledge the boundaries of our knowledge and become comfortable saying "I don't know" or "My understanding is incomplete"?
- Holding Multiple Truths:** How can we develop the capacity to validate perspectives different from our own without feeling that they invalidate or threaten our personal understanding?
- Contextual Validity:** How do we know when certain perspectives hold greater relevance or importance in specific situations while still respecting the inherent value of diverse viewpoints?



Close to the roots.



See the whole forest.



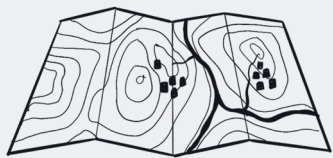
LISTENING

How to practice active listening with a more humanitarian ear? Learn how to pay attention to your surroundings and yourself. There are many reasons why we choose to stop listening. Can we use those incidences to learn how to stay curious?

- Here are a few friendly active **listening** reminders:

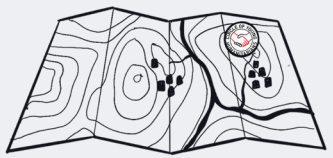
- Listen without judgement**
 - You rarely have the full picture. Invite questions instead.
- Listen without the need to solve**
 - You don't always need to provide a solution. Some stories just need to be witnessed.
- Listen without the need to fully understand**
 - You don't always need to know right away. Trust the process.
- Listen for feedback**
 - You don't always have it figured out. That's a good thing.
- Listen while recognizing your privilege**
 - Leave room for marginalized voices and challenge your biases
 - You can turn listening into a collaboration and learning opportunity
- Listen closely and openly**
 - You can practice listening with both your heart and mind. Remember, things make sense from people's perspective. Otherwise they wouldn't say it.
- Listen to music that touches your soul**
 - Again and again
- Listen to yourself**
 - Recognize when you need a break from listening :)

HUMANITARIAN LANDSCAPES



CONCRETE CONTOURS

Every humanitarian journey starts differently. Will there be a hill to climb? Water sources? A safe place to rest? By observing our specific surroundings, we find important information. Each landscape is so different and offers unique insights.



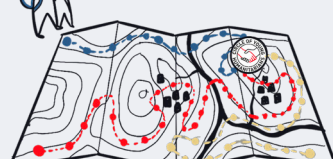
DESTINATION

Knowing where you're headed helps navigate obstacles, but a fixed destination may be the biggest obstacle. The CYH journey sees the destination as guiding principles rather than a rigid endpoint. For that, you need a reliable compass.



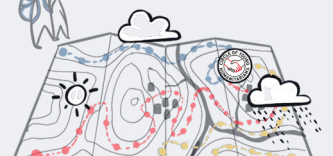
BITE-SIZE DESTINATIONS

It's about the journey! Every moment is a chance to realign, turning small acts of humanity into mini-destinations. Sharing a snack on a cliff. Jumping into a lake. Enjoying these moments as much as the final view.



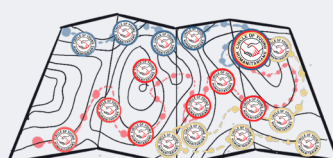
SUBJECTIVE TRAVELER

We each experience landscapes differently. One person finds mountains inspiring, another intimidating. Our daily paths include not just physical terrain but emotional and socio-political landscapes. The CYH journey embraces these differences, recognizing our needs are personal and ever-changing.



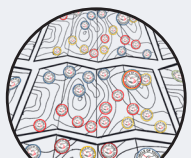
WEATHER DEPENDENT

Unpredictable forces shape our journey—like sudden weather changes. We prepare as best we can, learning from patterns over time. The CYH journey acknowledges that uncertainty is inevitable but navigable.



TAPESTRY OF CYH JOURNEYS

Joining the CYH journey doesn't mean changing your life's course but weaving guiding principles into it. By showing up for our humanity, we better recognize our shared connections.



GLOBAL BOND

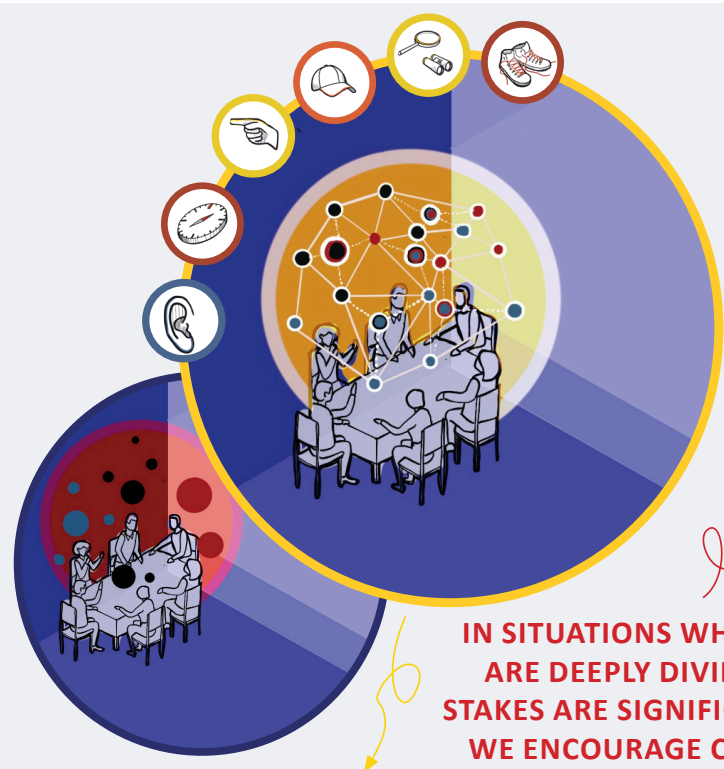
Tend to your relationships. Tend to your environments. We have one Earth in need of more human decency. The CYH journey values small, meaningful acts, reinforcing our connection to humanity across our worlds.



SWISS LANDSCAPE

Switzerland is privileged, with a stable environment. How to recognize Switzerland's roll on a global scale.

HUMANITARIAN SKILLS & TOOLS



IN SITUATIONS WHERE OPINIONS ARE DEEPLY DIVIDED AND THE STAKES ARE SIGNIFICANT, HOW CAN WE ENCOURAGE CONSTRUCTIVE DIALOGUE?

TRANSFORM POLARIZED DISCUSSION

Communication Approaches

The Palestine-Israel debate is a complex and often polarizing topic. Let's frame the conversation with a focus on encouraging discussion and collaboration, while also highlighting how impartiality can arise from a position of distance. Just because the discussion is difficult, it doesn't mean it should be avoided.

- Stay Calm and Composed:** In discussions about Israel-Palestine conflict, emotions often run high. It's vital to remain calm, which helps others feel safe to express their viewpoints without fear of escalation.
- Listen Actively:** Acknowledge that both Palestinians and Israelis have deeply held beliefs and lived traumas in this conflict. Listening actively to diverse narratives—whether you engage with stories from Palestinian families affected by occupation or Israeli families fearing history repeating itself—can foster greater understanding.
- Ask Open-Ended Questions:** Invite open dialogue by asking questions like "What are your thoughts on how both communities perceive their right to self-determination?" This encourages participants to explore their views thoughtfully rather than defensively.
- Acknowledge Emotions:** Recognize that this topic is highly emotional for many. Validating the feelings of those affected on both sides can reduce tension and lead to more productive discussions.
- Focus on Common Ground:** Emphasized shared interests, such as the desire for peace, security, and dignity for all people. Finding common goals can shift the focus from division to collaboration.
- Use "I" Statements:** When presenting your own views, say something like, "I believe that both sides have suffered tremendous losses," rather than making blanket statements about one side being entirely right or wrong.
- Avoid Ad Hominem Attacks:** Encourage respectful debate and discourage personal attacks. For example, criticizing someone's character instead of their argument can hinder constructive discussion.

Addressing the Dynamics of Bullying and Power

- Clarify Power Dynamics:** In the context of the Israel-Palestine debate, it's important to discuss the power imbalance. One narrative often emphasizes the struggles of Palestinians living under occupation, while another focuses on Israelis' right to security. Highlighting these dynamics invites deeper conversations about justice and empowerment.
- Differentiate Punching Up vs. Punching Down:** When advocating for Palestinian rights, clarify that advocating for a marginalized group involves "punching up" against institutional powers rather than "punching down" on those who are already struggling. This ensures the conversation is framed as one of support rather than division.
- Encourage Accountability and Empathy:** Ask people how they would feel if they were in the shoes of those affected by violence, displacement, or occupation. This approach fosters empathy and can lead to solidarity rather than conflict. Avoid hypotheticals that implicitly judge someone's actions. You simply cannot know what you'd do in their exact shoes.
- Reframe Challenges:** Encourage a focus on human rights and justice rather than solely political agendas. For example, discussing the need for humanitarian aid, access to services, and protection for civilians can help shift discussions toward actionable solutions and better outcomes.

Impartiality in Perspective

Finally, it's important to recognize that having an impartial perspective can often be easier for those without direct ties or experiences in the conflict:

Limited Personal Stake: Individuals who do not have personal ties to the conflict may approach discussions with less emotional investment, allowing them to analyze the situation from a broader perspective. They can see the human aspects of both narratives without feeling the weight of personal loss and trauma. Do not judge others for having these feelings. Feelings are entirely valid, and often, they belong to a lived experience closer to the truth.

Broadened Perspectives: Those without "skin in the game" may be more receptive to hearing and valuing diverse experiences, making it easier for them to advocate for peace without being perceived as biased toward one side.

Critical Thinking: An impartial stance can foster critical thinking and encourage individuals to seek evidence-based solutions rather than emotional reactions, contributing to more constructive dialogues.

All these pointers are suggestions that offer a starting point to think about these scenarios with a more humanitarian lens. We recommend you engage and expand on them as you see fit.

COMMUNITY ENGAGEMENT

Witnessing egocentric behavior, like that often displayed by authoritarians, can serve as a powerful motivator to cultivate a more community-minded approach.

- Start Small at Home:** Begin my helping family members, like offering to assist your brother with their homework. Communal acts set the foundation for broader community involvement.
- Volunteer Locally:** Research local organizations or causes that resonate with you. Sign up to help regularly.
- Join Local Groups:** Look for community organizations, clubs, or forums that align with your interests—be it environmental issues, social justice, or cultural initiatives. Engaging in discussions and activities widens your perspective and connects you with like-minded individuals.

4. Share Your Skill: Offer to teach a skill you possess or use it to support an effort you care about. This not only gives back but also fosters connections that empower others.

5. Become more Aware: Reflect on community involvement and its impact. Stay committed to building connections and supporting those around you, fostering a sense of belonging over self-interest.

Channeling Frustration into actionable steps can actively contribute to a more connected and compassionate community, helping to dissolve ego-driven tendencies in yourself and others.

Can you come up with other approaches?

INTERGENERATIONAL DIALOGUE

We model the behaviour we're exposed to, unless we intentionally decide not to. Children are especially impressionable and discerning. Consider this dialogue between parent and child:

Parent: I'm pretty upset by Trump's blatant lying. What do you think of it?

Child: He reminds me of the bullies at school who spread lies. I ignore them because I don't want to get involved.

Parent: I get that, but ignoring it can seem like you're accepting it. What if you spoke up and supported the person being bullied?

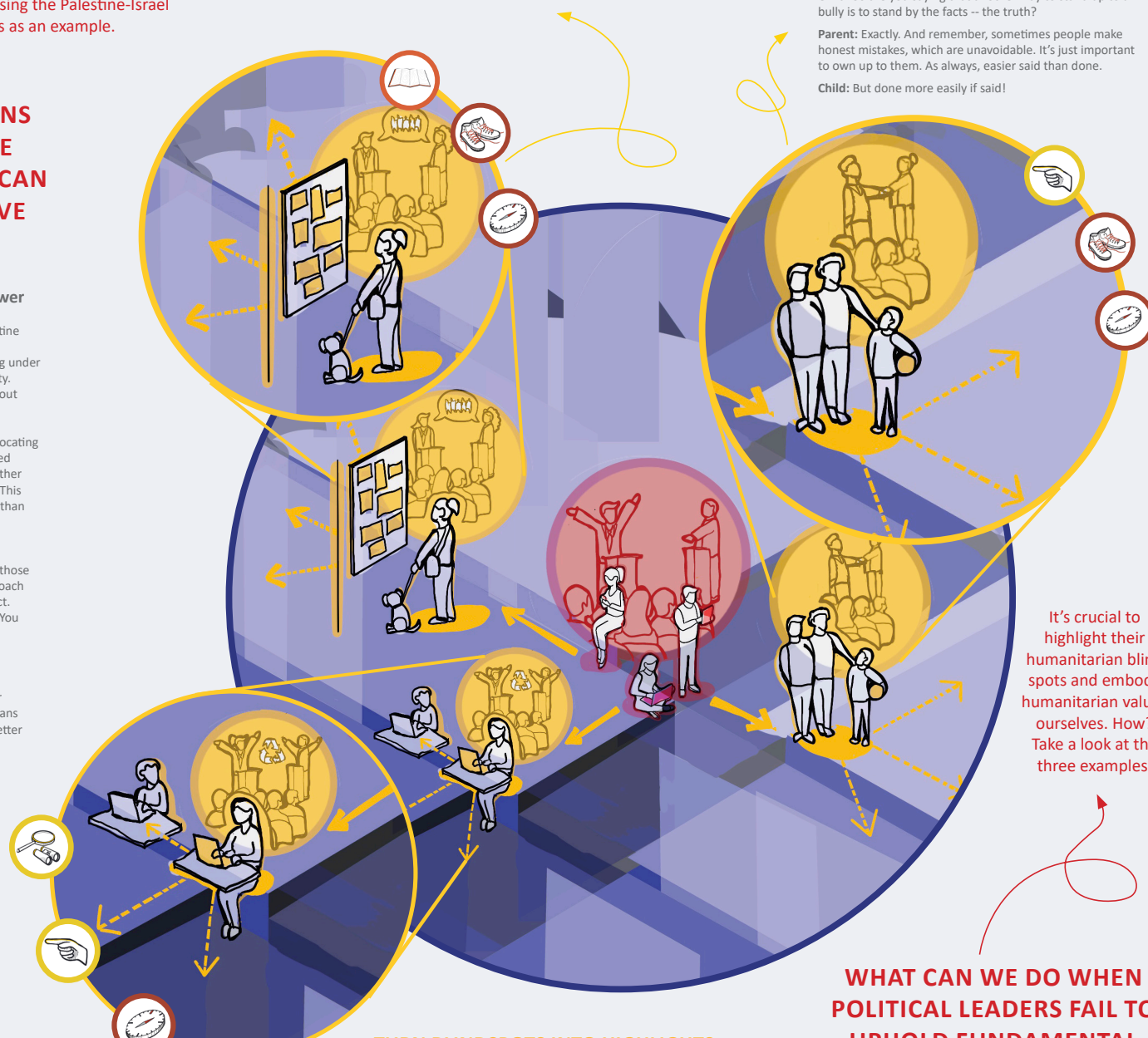
Child: But the bully is big and scary!

Parent: The right thing is never the easy way. Remember, it's not just about you; it's about supporting others, too. If it's dangerous to face the bully, you can always stand by the facts, which are not the same as opinions. Ask questions. Do research.

Child: So are you saying that another way to stand up to a bully is to stand by the facts – the truth?

Parent: Exactly. And remember, sometimes people make honest mistakes, which are unavoidable. It's just important to own up to them. As always, easier said than done.

Child: But done more easily if said!



WHAT CAN WE DO WHEN POLITICAL LEADERS FAIL TO UPHOLD FUNDAMENTAL HUMANITARIAN VALUES, AND HOW CAN WE RESIST THE NORMALIZATION OF SUCH BEHAVIORS?

TURN BLINDSPOTS INTO HIGHLIGHTS

It's one thing to assert that that you don't support a particular stance; it's another to articulate what you truly believe in. Take the time to clearly define your values and the issues/topics that matter most to you, and make a conscious effort to weave them into your professional and personal life. For journalists, for example, this could mean reflecting on how their writing can either promote or undermine these values. They may consider how they can use their platform to amplify the causes they stand for, encourage meaningful dialogue, as well as how this might reflect on the impact of their writing style.



COMMUNICATION

Communication is hard, especially when you feel like your safety is on the line. Can we learn how to communicate in more democratic ways? Where those more reluctant to speak, feel encouraged to do so, and those who dominate the airwaves are challenged to listen more?

- Helpful **communication** steps:

- Listen Actively** – Pay full attention to the speaker without interrupting. Show understanding by paraphrasing or asking clarifying questions.
 - Emotional Regulation** – Notice your own emotional shifts. Take a couple of breaths and pauses if you need some space.
 - Speak with Empathy** – Consider the emotions and perspectives of others before responding. Use "I" statements to express yourself without blaming (e.g., "I feel concerned when..." instead of "You always...").
 - Be Mindful of Tone and Body Language** – Nonverbal cues like facial expressions, gestures, and tone of voice can significantly impact how messages are received. Aim for warmth and openness.
 - Choose Words Carefully** – Use inclusive and respectful language. Avoid judgmental or harsh words that can create defensiveness or conflict.
 - Practice Patience and Openness** – Allow space for dialogue, even in disagreements. Approach conversations with curiosity rather than the intent to "win" or prove a point.
- There are all sorts of tools out there that expand on each step. Consider researching the Circle Process (name not related to CYH), which has its roots in indigenous conflict resolution and community strengthening. It's a restorative justice practice.

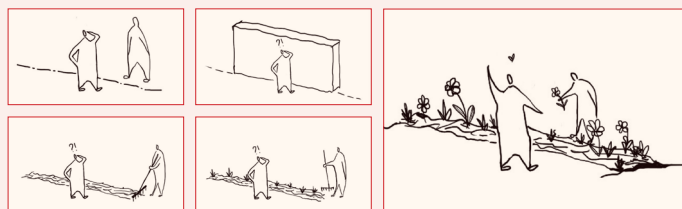


PROTECTION

Humanitarian work, while deeply rewarding, can expose you to emotional burnout and unpredictable challenges—much like facing burns and stormy weather without protection.

- Healthy boundaries, a form of **protection**:

- Learning to establish personal boundaries isn't just self-preservation; it's essential for sustainable service. True boundaries aren't walls that isolate you from those you aim to engage with, but thoughtful thresholds that allow for more authentic engagement.
- By knowing when to step back and prioritize your wellbeing, you transform potential points of depletion into opportunities for deeper connection.
- This shift in perspective—seeing boundaries as bridges rather than barriers—enables you to weather the inevitable storms of humanitarian work while maintaining your passion and presence for those who need you most.



- Communicating boundaries is a lifelong endeavor; you will fail many times and disappoint many people in the process.
- It takes time, patience, and intention, like growing a garden!



STEP FORWARD

How to move forward with your renewed skills and tools? Learn how to trust the next small step, even if you make mistakes along the way and even if it feels uncomfortable. Celebrate small steps and wins.

- Reflection as a way to **step forward**:

- Reflect on how each new step feels, celebrating small wins with your community along the way.
- Take note of mistakes without judgment, considering how you might approach things differently next time.
- Embrace playfulness and learn to laugh at your missteps—remember, being human means being beautifully imperfect!
- Share your victories, however modest, with others and take genuine joy in their successes too.
- By keeping collective humanitarian long-term goals in focus, you create a supportive ecosystem where individual growth contributes to shared progress.
- This balanced approach—honoring the process, learning from setbacks, finding joy in the journey, and staying connected to your community—transforms personal development into a meaningful shared experience.
- Each step uplifts humanity on this very planet earth.

One small step for each human, one large step for humanity.